

# ***General Knowledge***

## ***Ancient History***

### **STUDY NOTES**

#### **The Mauryan Empire**



# The Mauryan Empire

## Major Facts in Chronological Order

- The Mauryan Empire began in **322 BCE** when **Chandragupta Maurya** overthrew the **Nanda** dynasty, with strategic guidance from his mentor, **Chanakya** a.k.a **VishnuGupta**.
- After defeating **Seleucus I** in **305 BCE**, Chandragupta expanded the empire to include present-day **Punjab** and **Afghanistan regions**.
- The capital city of the Mauryan Empire was **Pataliputra**, located at the confluence of important trade routes.
- The empire was divided into provinces (**Mahajanapadas**). Each province was governed by appointed officials called **Uparikas**, who implemented the Emperor's policies at the regional level.
- The official responsible for **taxation** in the Mauryan Empire was called the **Samaharta**.
- Chanakya's **Arthashastra** laid the groundwork for governance, offering advice on administration, economics, and military strategies.
- The **Greek** ambassador **Megasthenes** visited Chandragupta's court and documented his observations in **Indica**, giving insights into **Mauryan society** and culture.
- Chandragupta's son, **Bindusara**, took over the throne in **297 BCE** and continued the expansion into southern India.
- **Ashoka**, the grandson of Chandragupta, ascended the throne around **268 BCE** and is remembered for his **transformative reign**.
- The Major Edicts of Ashoka are a set of **14** detailed rock inscriptions by the Indian emperor Ashoka. **The languages used in Ashoka's edicts were Prakrit, Greek, and Aramaic.**
- **Rock Edict II**, also known as the **Kalinga Edict**, describes Ashoka's remorse for the suffering caused by the **Kalinga War** and his commitment to promoting **peace**.
- **Pillar Edict V**: This edict lists animals and birds that should not be killed on some days, and other animals that should not be killed. It also describes the release of **25** prisoners by Ashoka.
- **Pillar Edict VI**: This edict deals with the **Dhamma Policy**.
- The **Ashoka Chakra** is an Indian symbol that is a depiction of the **Dharma Chakra**. The **24** spokes represent the twelve causal links taught by the **Buddha**.
- The pivotal **Kalinga War** in **261 BCE** resulted in significant loss of life, profoundly changing Ashoka's outlook towards violence and war.

- Following the war, **Ashoka** embraced **Buddhism**, promoting its principles of peace and non-violence throughout his empire.
- He initiated the concept of **Dhamma**, which emphasized moral governance, social welfare, and respect for all living beings.
- Ashoka became a major patron of Buddhism, facilitating the spread of the religion to various parts of **Asia**, including **Sri Lanka**.
- He dispatched missionaries, including his son **Mahinda** and daughter **Sanghamitra**, to spread Buddhism beyond India.
- After Ashoka died in **232 BCE**, the empire struggled with weak successors, leading to a gradual decline.
- The last Mauryan emperor, **Brihadratha**, faced internal challenges and was ultimately assassinated by his general, **Pushyamitra Shunga**, in **180 BCE**.

## Detailed View Of the Mauryan Dynasty

- The Mauryan empire was founded by **Chandragupta Maurya** around **322 BCE**.
- The **Mauryan Empire** was a geographically extensive historical power belonging to the **Iron Age**.
- Three famous rulers of the Mauryan dynasty who took the glory of the Mauryan empire to peak were **Chandragupta Maurya**, **Bindusara**, and **Ashoka**.
- The political unity was achieved for the first time in Indian history under the Maurya's reign. With the conquest of the Indo-Gangetic plain, the empire was centralized.
- The capital city of the Mauryan empire was **Pataliputra** (present-day **Patna**).
- The republic and oligarchy form of government came to an end and the Monarchy reached excellence under the Mauryas.
- The empire was known for its exceptional creativity in the fields of literature, art, architecture, and inscriptions.
- The **Lion Capital of Ashoka** which is the national emblem of India belongs to this era.
- The Mauryan empire came to an end by **180 BCE** and the last ruler of the dynasty was **Brihadratha**.

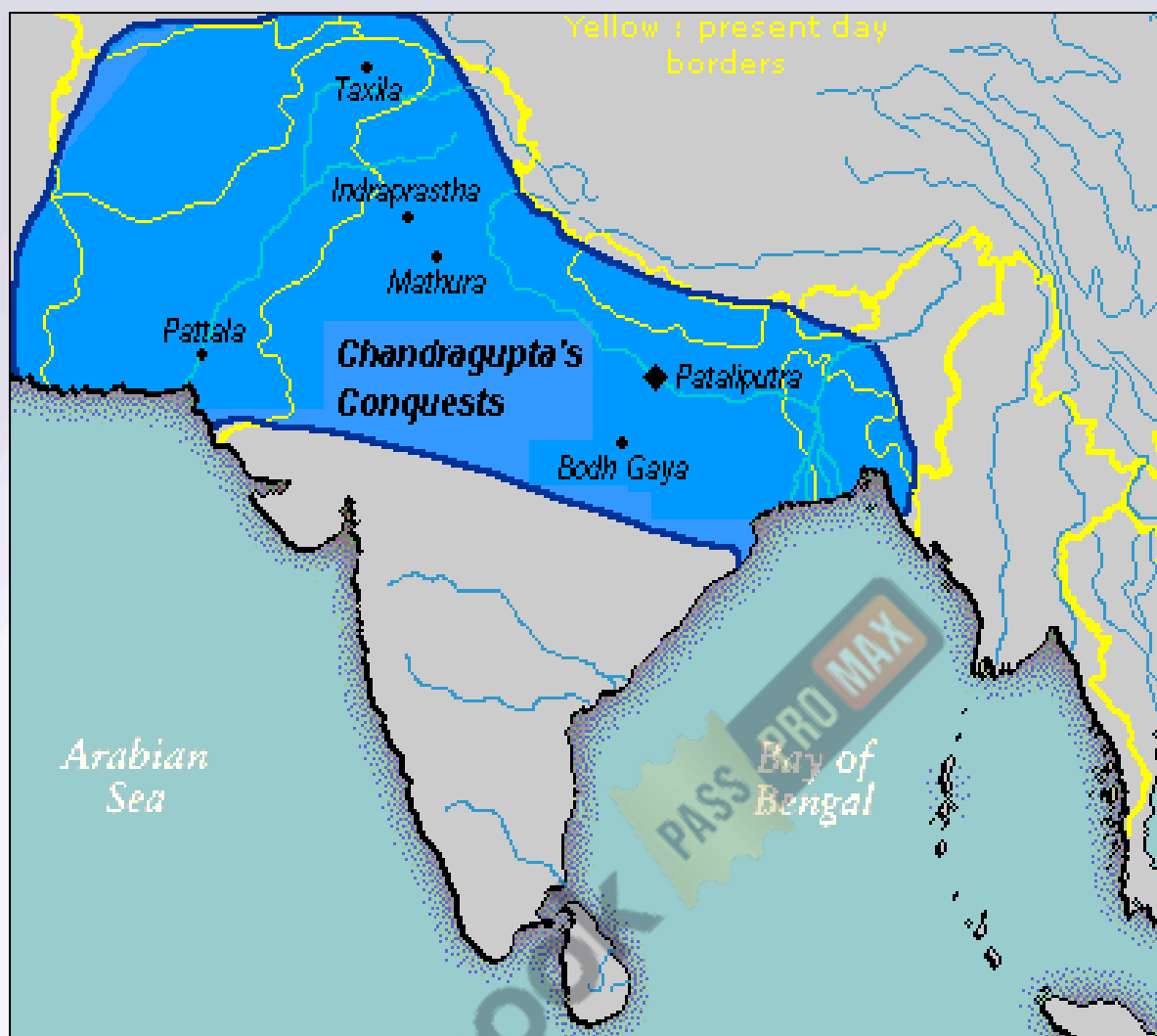
## Mauryan Empire - Genealogy

| Ruler (Kings)       | Ruling Period (BCE) |
|---------------------|---------------------|
| Chandragupta Maurya | 322 - 297 BCE       |
| Bindusara           | 297 - 272/268 BCE   |

|              |                   |
|--------------|-------------------|
| Ashoka       | 272/268 - 232 BCE |
| Dasharatha   | 232 - 224 BCE     |
| Samprati     | 224 - 215 BCE     |
| Shalishuka   | 215 - 202 BCE     |
| Devavarman   | 202 - 195 BCE     |
| Shatadhanvan | 195 - 187 BCE     |
| Brihadratha  | 187 - 180 BCE     |

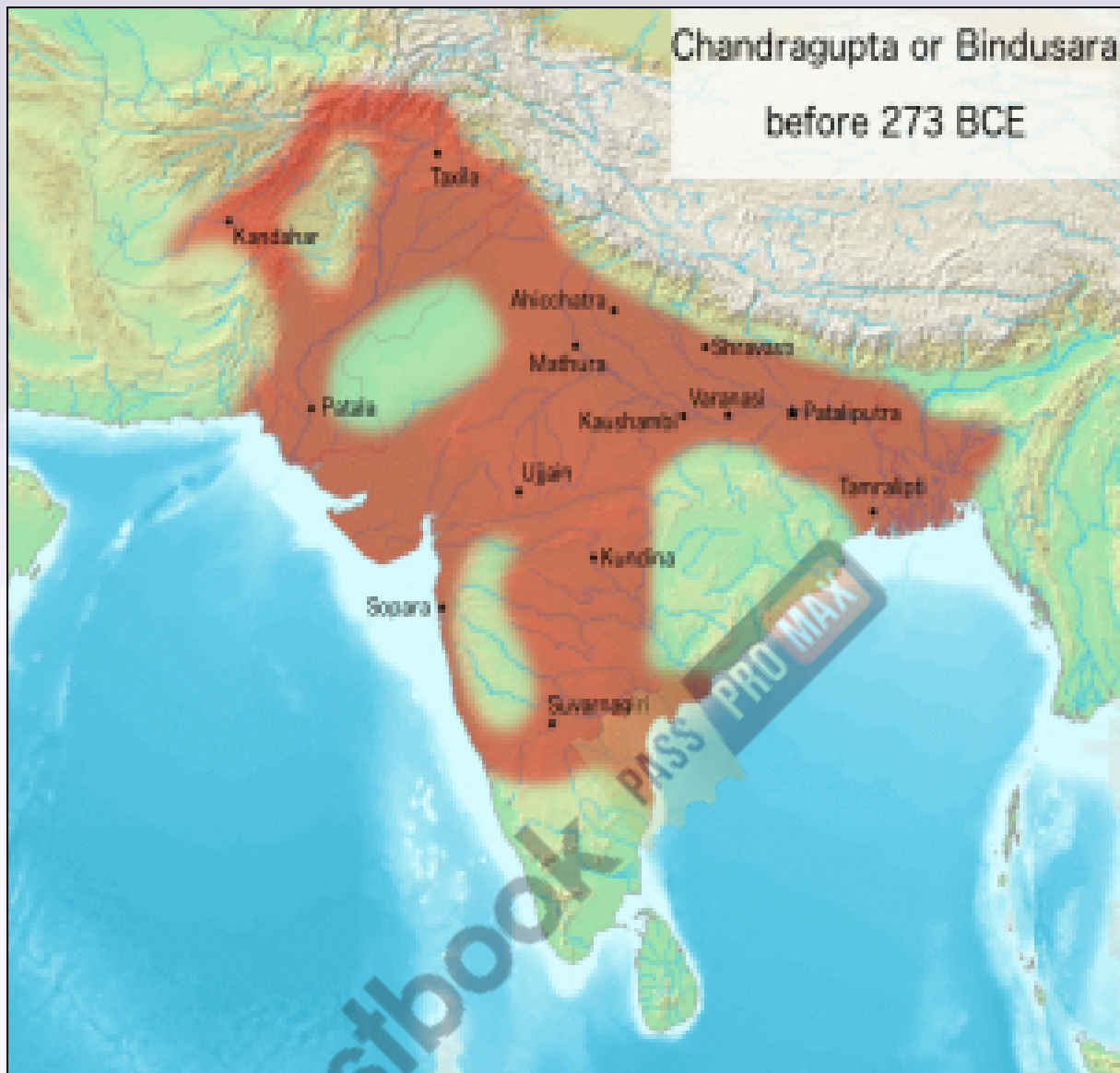
### 1. Chandragupta Maurya

- **Chandragupta Maurya** was the founder of the Mauryan dynasty.
- According to the Brahmanical traditions he was born of a shudra woman in the Nandas court. But as per the Buddhist tradition, a Kshatriya clan called Mauryas existed in the Gorakhpur region.
- He took advantage of the decline and weakness of the Nandas. He overthrew the last ruler of the Nanda dynasty, **Dhanananda** with the help of **Chanakya (Kautilya)** and crowned himself as the emperor.
- North Western India was under the realm of **Seleucus**. Chandragupta Maurya liberated Afghanistan, Baluchistan, and areas to the west of the Indus from Seleucus in return for 500 elephants.
- He brought a vast region under the Mauryan Empire, which included Bihar, Orissa and Bengal, along with the North and Northwestern parts of the Indian subcontinent.
- **Kerala, Tamil Nadu**, and parts of **North East** were the only parts that were not under the Mauryan rule.
- Chandragupta Maurya was an **autocrat**, who kept all powers in his hands.
- The most striking feature of his administration was the maintenance of the huge army. According to Pliny, a Roman writer, Chandragupta had 600000 soldiers, 30000 cavalry, and 9000 elephants.



## 2. Bindusara

- **Chandragupta Maurya** was succeeded by his son **Bindusara**.
- Greeks called him by the names **Amitragata**, **Amitrochates**, and **Allitrochates** which means slayer of enemies.
- **Bindusara** extended the Mauryan empire as far as the south. Sixteen states were brought under the empire by him, thereby conquering the Indian peninsula.
- Other than the southern states, the only kingdom which was not under the control of Bindusara was **Kalinga**.
- His reign was important for the continued links with the **Greeks**.
- **Kautilya** continued as prime minister during his period.



### 3. Ashoka

- **Ashoka** was the Son of **Bindusara**, he was one of the greatest kings of the Indian Subcontinent.
- First ruler to maintain direct contact with his people through his inscriptions.
- In the **Maski Edict**, he was named Ashoka.
- Ashokan inscriptions - numbering 39 classified as **Major Rock edicts, Minor Rock edicts, Separate Rock edicts, Major Pillar edicts, and Minor Pillar edicts.**
- The stone pillars were made in **Chunar** near Varanasi and transported to north and south India.
- The name of Ashoka occurs only in copies of **minor rock edict 1** found at three places in Karnataka and one in Madhya Pradesh.

- All other inscriptions mention only **Devanampiya Piyadasi**.
- Ashokan inscriptions are found in **India, Nepal, Pakistan, and Afghanistan**.
- **They are generally placed on ancient highways.**
- **The contemporary rulers of Ashoka were:**
  - **Antiochius II of Syria**
  - **Ptolemy II of Egypt**
  - **Antigonos of Macedonia**
  - **Magas of Cyrenaica(libya)**
  - **Alexander of Epirus**
- **In the greater part of the subcontinent, they are composed in Prakrit and written in Brahmi.** In the northwestern part of the continent, they are composed in **Aramaic** language and **Kharosthi** script. And in Afghanistan, they appeared in both **Aramaic and Greek scripts.**
- The **third Buddhist Council** was conducted under the patronage of **Emperor Ashoka**. It was held in 250 BC at **Pataliputra**. The council was presided over by **Mogaliputta Tissa**. The main objective was to purify Buddhism from opportunistic factions and corruption in the Sangha.

### Impact of the Kalinga War

- Ashoka abandoned the policy of physical occupation and adopted the policy of cultural conquest. It can be said that policy shifts from **Bherighosha to Dhammaghosha**.
- **State policy was made on the principles of Buddhism.**
- Ashoka no longer treated foreign territories as legitimate areas for military conquest. He tried to conquer them ideologically.
- **He sent ambassadors of peace to Greece and West Asia.**
- **He sent his son Mahendra and Daughter Sanghamitra to Ceylon.**

### Internal policy of Ashoka and Buddhism

- He appointed a class of officers known as the **Rajukas** who were vested with the authority of not only rewarding people but also punishing them for the violation of the established rules.
- **The third Buddhist Council (Sangiti) was held by Ashoka and missionaries were sent to Sri Lanka, Burma, and other countries to convert people there.**
- Ashoka set a very high ideal of paternal kingship that the king looked upon his subjects as his children.

- He appointed **Dhamma mahamatras** to propagate dharma among various social groups including women.
- His teachings were meant to strengthen the institution of the family and the existing social order.

| Edicts                                       | Messages                                                                |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>First Rock Edit</b>                       | Prohibition of animal Sacrifices                                        |
| <b>Fourth Rock Edict</b>                     | Bheri Ghosa was replaced by Dhamma Ghosa                                |
| <b>Fifth Rock Edict</b>                      | Appointment of Dhamma Mahammattas                                       |
| <b>Thirteenth Edict</b>                      | The Kalinga war (BCE 261)                                               |
| <b>Rummindei Inscription (Nepal)</b>         | To Commemorate the birthplace of the Buddha.<br>Ashoka visited Lumbini, |
| <b>Kalinga Edict</b>                         | All men are my Children                                                 |
| <b>Saugara Copper Plate Inscription</b>      | Relief measures adopted during famine in Magadha                        |
| <b>Shahbazgarhi and Manshera</b>             | Kharosthi                                                               |
| <b>Brahmagiri Minor Rock Edicts I and II</b> | Talks about Local Administration                                        |

### Ashoka's place in history

- **Great missionary ruler in history**
- He brought about the **political unification of the country**.
- Because of his missionary activities in Ashoka cultural contact was established between developed Gangetic basins and backward areas of the provinces.
- **Ashoka** promotes the cultural contacts between Indian states and between India and the other world too. **Ashoka** is considered the **First Global Ambassador of India**.

## Significance of the Mauryan Empire

### Imperial organization

- Very elaborate organization - we know about it from the historical account of “Indica” written by Megasthenes and the Arthashastra written by Chanakya.
- Megasthenes was the ambassador of Seleucus who lived in Pataliputra which was the capital of the Mauryan empire and wrote elaborately about the Mauryan administration.

### Features of the Mauryan administration

- Autocratic administration (concentration of all the powers in the hands of the ruler)
- King was assisted by the council and the advice of the council was not binding.
- High officers were chosen from the councillors
- The empire was divided into provinces and each province was placed under a prince.

| State         | Capital       |
|---------------|---------------|
| Uttarapatha   | Taxila        |
| Dakshinapatha | Suvarnagiri   |
| Eastern India | Tosali        |
| Avantiratha   | Ujjain        |
| Kalinga       | Tasali/Dhauri |

- Separate arrangements were made for rural and urban administration.
- The administration of Pataliputra was carried out by six committees consisting of five members.
- The most striking feature of the administration was the maintenance of the huge army.
- The administrative mechanisms were backed by an elaborate system of espionage.
- There was an enormous gap between the highest and the lowest category of servants.

### Important functionaries (tirthas)

|                    |                 |
|--------------------|-----------------|
| Minister           | <i>Mantrin</i>  |
| Highest priest     | <i>Purohita</i> |
| Commander in chief | <i>Senapati</i> |
| Crown prince       | <i>yuvaraja</i> |

### Important Officials

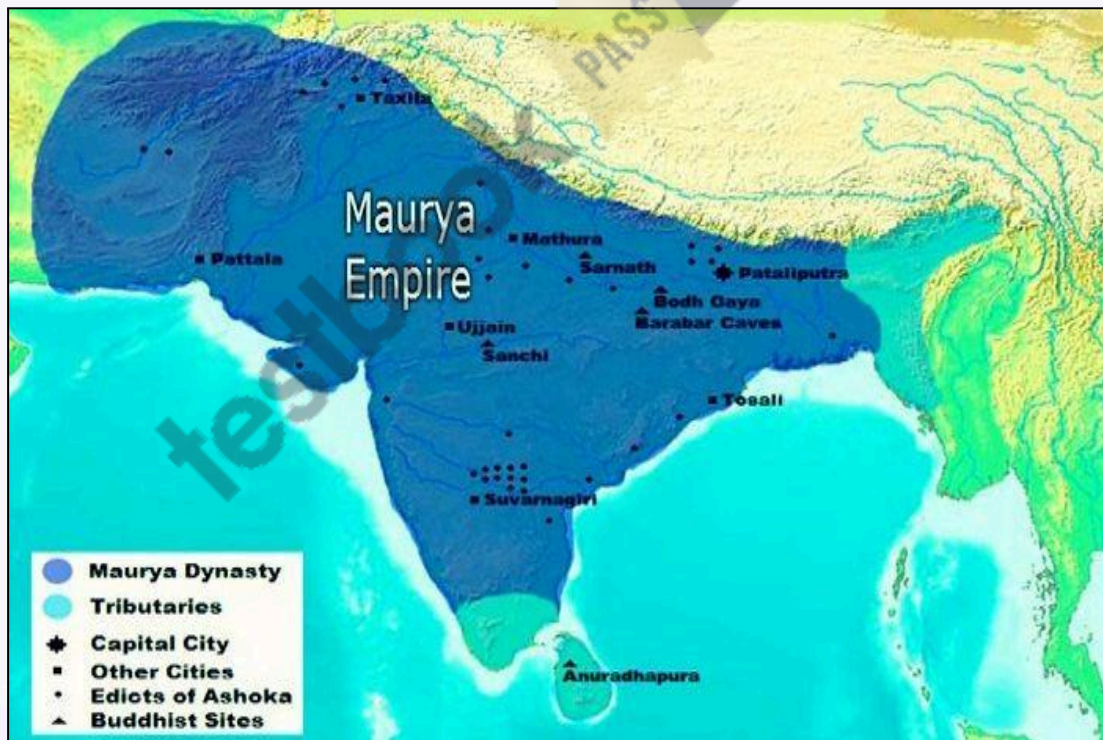
| Title/Designation           | Description                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Samnidhata                  | Chief treasury officer                                                                             |
| Samaharta                   | Collector general of revenue                                                                       |
| Vyavaharika<br>(Dharmastha) | Chief Justice of Dharmasthiya Nyayalaya (Civil Court)                                              |
| Pradeshta                   | Chief Justice of Kantakashodhan Nyayalaya (Criminal Court)                                         |
| Dhamma Mahamatra            | Post created by Ashoka for propagating Dhamma and ensuring material well-being of the common folk. |
| Rashtrapala/Kumara          | Viceroy in charge of a province                                                                    |
| Pradesika                   | The modern equivalent of a district magistrate                                                     |
| Rajukas                     | Equivalent to Patwaris, responsible for surveying and land assessment                              |
| Yukta                       | Subordinate revenue officer at the district level                                                  |
| Sthanika                    | Collecting officers directly under the control of the Pradesika                                    |
| Gopa                        | Responsible for accounts                                                                           |

### Arrangement of army

- Army
- Navy
- Cavalry
- Elephants
- Chariots
- Transport

### Features of the Economy of the State

- **The state controls all the activities**
- The state brought the **new lands under cultivation**
- Taxes collected from the peasants varied from one-fourth to one-sixth of the produce.
- In times of emergency, peasants were supposed to grow more crops.
- **The state enjoyed a monopoly in mining, the sale of liquor, the manufacturing of arms, etc.**



- 27 superintendents (**adhyakshas**) were appointed to regulate the economic activities of the state.
- **According to Arthashastra, the striking development of the Mauryan empire was the employment of slaves in agricultural operations.**
- State-maintained farms on which numerous slaves and hired laborers were employed.

- The ***Samaharta*** was the **highest officer in charge of assessment and *Sannidhata*** was the **chief custodian of the state treasury and storehouse**. Greater importance was attached to the assessment than to store and deposit. Taxes were also collected in kind.
- **Punched marked silver coins, which carry the symbols of a peacock, and hill crescent** formed the imperial currency of the Mauryans.

## Art and Architecture

- **Mauryans introduced stone masonry on a wide scale.**
- High skill was attained by the Mauryan artisans in polishing the stone.
- Each pillar is made of a single piece of **buff-colored sandstone**.
- The Mauryan artisans also started the practice of hewing out caves from rocks for monks to live in. The earliest example is the **Barabar caves near Gaya**.

## Important cultural elements

- **Ashokan pillar Lauriya Nandangarh (Bihar)**



- **Bull capital Rampurva**



- Lomasrishi caves, Barabar hills



### Spread of material culture and state system

- Mauryan conquest opened the doors for **trade and missionary activities** which led to the spread of material culture.
- The material culture of Mauryan times was based on the **intensive use of iron**, the prevalence of writing, plenty of punch-marked coins, an abundance of beautiful pottery called Northern Black Polished Ware, the introduction of burnt bricks, and ring wells.
- This period shows **socketed axes, Sickels, and plowshare**. The **spoked wheel** also came to be used.
- In the Mauryan period, **burnt bricks were used for the first time in north-eastern India**.
- **Ring-well first appeared** in Gangetic plains during the Mauryan period.

### Literary Sources of the Mauryan Empire:

#### 1. Arthashastra:

- **Arthashastra** was written by **Kautilya** in **Sanskrit**.
- Kautilya was the contemporary of **Chandragupta Maurya**.
- **Arthashastra** deals with the entire legal and bureaucratic framework required for the administration of the kingdom.

- The Arthashastra emphasized the king's duty to promote the welfare (**Yogakshema**) of his people, not just through law and order, but by ensuring agricultural productivity, irrigation, fair taxation, and disaster relief.
- It was compiled a few centuries after the Maurya rule, yet this book contains authentic information about the Mauryan administration.
- It serves to be the most important source of the Mauryan empire.
- It contains **15** books and **180** chapters and they are divided into **3** broad divisions.

## 2. Mudrarakshasa

- **Mudrarakshasa** is a drama written by **Visakadata** in **Sanskrit**.
- Though this piece of work belongs to the **Gupta era**, it gives an image of the **socio-economic** conditions under the Mauryas.
- The victory of **Chandragupta Maurya** over Nandas under the guidance of **Kautilya** is elaborated in this.

## 3. Indica

- **Indica** was written by **Megasthenes**, a Greek ambassador who was sent by Seleucus to **Chandragupta** Maurya's court.
- He wrote an account of the administration of the capital city, **Pataliputra**, and the **Mauryan empire** as well.
- His works were not available in full and the fragments of his works were collected and compiled by the Greek writers. This compilation was published under the name **Indica**.
- Apart from these three major sources, some of the **Buddhist** literature and Puranas draw an account of the Mauryan empire.

## Decline of the Mauryan Empire:

The Mauryan empire began to disintegrate with the end of Ashoka's reign in **232 BCE**. Several factors led to the decline and fall of the vast empire. The causes are widely debated by scholars.

### 1. Brahmanical Reaction

- Though Ashoka adopted the policy of **religious tolerance**, he was against the killing of animals and birds and also prohibited superstitious sacrifices and rituals performed by women.
- This **anti-sacrifice** attitude of Ashoka brought about the loss to the **Brahmanical society**, who lived on the offers made in the name of sacrifices.
- This turned the Brahmanas against Ashoka and developed some kind of antipathy towards him.

### 2. Financial Crisis

- The Mauryan empire was known for maintaining the largest army and the largest regiment of officers in ancient times.
- This led to huge expenditures on payments to the army and the bureaucrats, thus resulting in economic constraints.
- Ashoka made huge grants out of the royal treasury to the Buddhist monks, which soon ran empty.
- In later periods, the images made of gold were melted to meet the expenses.

### 3. Oppressive Rule

- During the reign of Bindusara, the people of **Taxila** complained about the misrule of the wicked bureaucrats. This was sorted by appointing Ashoka.
- This was repeated during the reign of Ashoka. He ordered the mahamatras to not torture the people without due cause.
- He introduced a rotation of officers in **Ujjain**, **Taxila**, and **Tosali** to address this issue. However, the oppression continued to exist in the outlying provinces.

### 4. Spread of the New Knowledge

- As a result of the expansion of the Mauryan empire, the knowledge of the material advantages of the Mauryas spread to central India, Kalinga, and Deccan.

- With this, the **Gangetic basin** which was the heart of the empire lost its special advantage.
- New kingdoms such as **Shungas**, **Kanvas**, and **Chetis** were founded and expanded based on this material knowledge gained from the Magadha.

### 5. Neglect of the North West Frontier

- Ashoka was preoccupied with missionary activities in the homeland and abroad. He failed to concentrate on the passages of the North West Frontier.
- The nomadic people were looked upon as a serious threat to India and China.
- So the then-ruler of China constructed the Great Wall of China to shield the empire against these attacks.
- No such measures were made by Ashoka. As a result, when Scythians approach India, they forced the Parthians, the Shakas, and the Greeks to move towards India.